

My Product Journey: Cricket Bat — Product Fact Card

How to use this card: This document provides detailed information about cricket bats. Read it carefully to extract facts for your graphic organiser.

Why Cricket Bat Matters — and Where It Comes From

The cricket bat is an essential piece of sporting equipment, central to the game of cricket, used by batsmen to hit the ball. In India, a major global hub for cricket bat manufacturing, bats are primarily crafted from two types of willow: Kashmir willow (*Salix alba caerulea*), known for its durability and affordability, and English willow (*Salix alba caerulea*), which is often preferred by professional players for its lightweight nature and superior 'ping' or rebound performance. The origins of cricket bat manufacturing in India trace back to the late 19th century, with local craftsmen in regions like Meerut in Uttar Pradesh, Jalandhar in Punjab, and the Kashmir Valley in Jammu & Kashmir establishing production. The foundation for the Kashmir willow industry was laid when the British introduced willow trees to the Kashmir Valley in the 1820s. Today, prominent Indian and international brands like SS (Sareen Sports Industries), SG (Sanspareils Greenlands), MRF (Madras Rubber Factory), BDM (B.D. Mahajan & Sons), DSC (Delux Sports Company), BAS (Beat All Sports), Kookaburra, New Balance, Ciel Sports, and Elevar Bats operate manufacturing facilities, predominantly located in these key clusters, catering to a vast market that produces around 3 million bats annually and accounts for approximately 70% of the global cricket bat market volume.

The Journey: From Willow to Cricket Bat

The journey of a cricket bat begins with **Willow Cultivation & Harvesting**, where farmers, loggers, and arborists cultivate willow trees (*Salix alba caerulea*) for 15-18 years in specific conditions, such as the Anantnag, Pulwama, Baramula, and Pahalgam districts of Jammu & Kashmir for Kashmir willow, or in Essex and Suffolk, UK, for English willow. These workers fell the mature trees in winter when sap levels are low, then cut the logs into rounds and carefully split them into raw clefts, avoiding sawing to preserve grain integrity. Next, at manufacturing hubs like Meerut (Uttar Pradesh), Jalandhar (Punjab), and the Kashmir Valley, **Cleft Inspection & Grading** is performed by graders and quality inspectors who meticulously examine each raw cleft for grain structure, density, and blemishes using measuring tapes and moisture meters, assigning grades (e.g., Grade 1, 2, 3, Player Grade) that determine the bat's final quality and price. Following this, seasoning technicians and laborers oversee the **Seasoning** process, where clefts undergo either natural air drying, which can take up to a year for Kashmir willow, or controlled kiln drying on racks to reduce moisture content and stabilize the wood, a critical step for bat performance and durability. In Meerut and Jalandhar, press operators then conduct **Hydraulic Pressing**, subjecting seasoned clefts to multiple stages of compression, for instance, 8 stages at Ciel Sports, using hydraulic presses to densify wood fibers and enhance the bat's 'ping' and durability, with essential resting periods between presses. Highly skilled bat carvers, artisans, and shapers in Meerut, Jalandhar, and the Kashmir Valley then perform **Profile Shaping & Carving**, using traditional tools like draw knives and spoke shaves, alongside modern band saws and lathes, to

precisely carve the cleft into the desired bat profile, including the spine, edges, and sweet spot. Handle makers and splicers then undertake **Handle Construction & Splicing**, gluing thin strips of cane, often imported from Singapore, to form the handle, which is then precisely spliced and glued into a prepared cavity in the bat blade using gluing jigs, metal molds, and presses, ensuring a strong and flexible joint. Sanders and polishers then execute **Sanding & Finishing**, using belt sanders, orbital sanders, and hand sanding blocks through multiple stages to achieve a smooth, polished surface. Finishers then apply linseed oil to condition the willow, fit a toe guard to protect the bottom edge, and may apply an anti-scuff sheet to the face for added protection during **Oiling, Toe Guard & Anti-Scuff Application**. Finally, branding specialists apply brand stickers and logos, often with heat presses, and grip fitters secure a rubber grip onto the handle using specialized tools during **Branding & Grip Fitting**, with each bat undergoing a final quality check before packaging and distribution from Meerut, Jalandhar, and the Kashmir Valley to domestic and international markets.

Raw Materials, Inputs, and Natural Resources

The production of a cricket bat relies on several key raw materials and inputs, with willow wood being the most crucial. Kashmir Willow Wood (*Salix alba caerulea*) is sourced from the Anantnag, Pulwama, Baramula, and Pahalgam districts in Jammu & Kashmir, with raw, unshaped clefts costing approximately Rs 650-1000 per piece. This willow is denser and harder, offering durability and affordability, and requires 15-18 years to mature. For professional-grade bats, English Willow Wood (*Salix alba caerulea*) is imported from specialist growers in regions like Essex and Suffolk in the UK, such as J.S. Wright & Sons. These imported clefts are significantly more expensive, ranging from Rs 1000 to Rs 7500 per piece, depending on their grade, and are prized for their lightweight structure, superior performance, and better 'ping.' The bat's flexible handle is constructed from cane, primarily imported from Singapore, which helps absorb shock and vibration. Other essential components include rubber grips, often sourced from manufacturers in India, particularly Jalandhar, which provide a comfortable and secure hold. Various glues and adhesives, also sourced from India, are used for joining the handle to the blade and for fitting protective elements like toe guards. Linseed oil, an Indian-sourced product, is applied to condition and protect the willow, while toe guards and anti-scuff sheets, also from India, provide crucial protection. Finally, branding materials and stickers, produced in India, are applied for brand identification and aesthetic appeal.

How Cricket Bat Is Made — Step by Step

The intricate process of crafting a cricket bat involves several precise stages, each performed by skilled workers:

- Willow Cultivation & Harvesting:** Farmers, loggers, and arborists cultivate willow trees for 15-18 years in regions like Anantnag, Pulwama, Baramula, and Pahalgam in Jammu & Kashmir, or in Essex and Suffolk, UK. These workers fell mature trees in winter using axes, wedges, and chainsaws, then transport the logs via tractors or trucks to be split into raw clefts, ensuring the grain integrity is preserved by avoiding sawing.
- Cleft Inspection & Grading:** Graders and quality inspectors at manufacturing hubs in Meerut, Jalandhar, and the Kashmir Valley meticulously examine raw willow clefts using measuring tapes and moisture meters. They assess grain structure, density, and blemishes, assigning grades (e.g., Grade 1, 2, 3, Player Grade) that dictate the bat's final performance and market value.
- Seasoning:** Seasoning technicians and laborers in Meerut, Jalandhar, or the Kashmir Valley manage the crucial drying process. Clefts are either naturally air-dried on racks, which can take up to a year for Kashmir willow, or subjected to controlled kiln drying to precisely reduce moisture content and stabilize the wood, a vital step for bat durability and performance.
- Hydraulic Pressing:** Press operators in facilities like Ciel Sports in Meerut or other factories in Jalandhar apply significant

force using hydraulic presses. Seasoned clefts undergo multiple pressing stages, for example, 8 stages, with essential resting periods in between, to compress the wood fibers, thereby enhancing the bat's characteristic 'ping' and overall resilience. 5. ****Profile Shaping & Carving:**** Highly skilled bat carvers, artisans, and shapers in Meerut, Jalandhar, and the Kashmir Valley meticulously transform the pressed clefts. They employ traditional tools such as draw knives and spoke shaves, alongside modern machinery like band saws and lathes, to carve the precise bat profile, carefully defining the spine, edges, and the critical sweet spot with paramount precision. 6. ****Handle Construction & Splicing:**** Handle makers and splicers, often in Meerut, Jalandhar, or the Kashmir Valley, craft the bat's handle by gluing thin strips of cane, primarily imported from Singapore, together. This flexible handle is then expertly spliced and securely glued into a prepared cavity within the bat blade, utilizing gluing jigs, metal molds, and presses to ensure a robust and shock-absorbing joint. 7. ****Sanding & Finishing:**** Sanders and polishers meticulously refine the bat's surface in manufacturing units across Meerut, Jalandhar, and the Kashmir Valley. They employ both belt sanders and orbital sanders, complemented by hand sanding blocks, through multiple stages to achieve an impeccably smooth, polished finish, preparing the willow for subsequent oiling and branding applications. 8. ****Oiling, Toe Guard & Anti-Scuff Application:**** Finishers carefully apply linseed oil to the bat using brushes to condition the willow, protecting it from moisture and enhancing its longevity. They then fit a durable toe guard to shield the bat's bottom edge and may apply an anti-scuff sheet to the bat's face for additional protection against impact, in locations like Meerut, Jalandhar, or the Kashmir Valley. 9. ****Branding & Grip Fitting:**** Branding specialists apply brand stickers and logos, often using heat presses, to the finished bat, while grip fitters secure a rubber grip onto the handle using specialized tools. This final stage, conducted in manufacturing hubs such as Meerut, Jalandhar, or the Kashmir Valley, concludes with a comprehensive quality check before the bat is packaged for distribution.

What It Costs to Bring Cricket Bat to You

The cost of a cricket bat builds up significantly from the raw material stage to its final retail price. The journey begins with the raw willow cleft, where a Kashmir Willow cleft costs a farmer or supplier approximately Rs 650-1000 per piece at the manufacturing unit gate, while an imported English Willow cleft can range from Rs 1000 to Rs 7500 or more, depending on its grade. Once the raw material is acquired, various processing and manufacturing costs are added. Cleft inspection and grading by quality inspectors add an estimated Rs 50-150 per cleft for labor and overhead. Seasoning technicians and laborers contribute Rs 100-300 per cleft for energy, space, and labor during the drying process. Press operators incur Rs 200-500 per cleft for energy, equipment, and labor during hydraulic pressing. Highly skilled bat carvers, artisans, and shapers add Rs 300-1000 per bat for their specialized labor in profile shaping. Handle makers and splicers add Rs 150-400 per bat for materials (cane, rubber) and labor for handle construction and splicing. Sanders, polishers, and finishers add Rs 100-300 per bat for labor, abrasives, and electricity during sanding and finishing, and another Rs 50-150 per bat for materials and labor during oiling, toe guard, and anti-scuff application. Finally, branding specialists and grip fitters add Rs 50-200 per bat for materials and labor during branding and grip fitting. Overall, direct labor costs for artisans and factory workers can range from Rs 300-1000+ per bat. Beyond manufacturing, significant costs are added for branding, marketing, and endorsements, especially for premium brands, along with logistics and distribution expenses. The retailer then adds their margin, which can be substantial, sometimes Rs 8,000-15,000+ for premium bats compared to factory-direct prices. Consequently, the final retail price for a cricket bat can range from Rs 1,500 to over Rs 40,000, depending on the willow type, grade, and brand. As of September 22, 2025, the Goods and Services Tax (GST) rate on cricket bats (HSN 9506) was reduced from 12% to 5% to promote youth sports,

making them more affordable.

What Cricket Bat Costs in Shops — Price Research

The price of a cricket bat varies significantly across different retail channels and depends heavily on the type and grade of willow, as well as the brand's reputation. For instance, a KIS Kashmir Willow Classic full-size (SH) bat, available from Made in Kashmir (Online) in Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir, is priced at Rs 3800. Similarly, an SS (Sareen Sports) SKY Player Kashmir Willow Cricket Bat, also full-size (SH), can be purchased for Rs 3850 from Nagrath Sports (Online). These prices reflect the affordability and durability associated with Kashmir willow bats, often sold directly or through online retailers with lower overheads. In contrast, English willow bats, preferred by professional players for their superior performance, command much higher prices. A Ciel Sports Striker Grade 1 English Willow Cricket Bat, full-size (SH), sold factory-direct online from Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, is priced at Rs 23999. This higher price point is attributed to the imported, higher-grade English willow and the brand's direct-to-consumer model. Moving to a premium brand, an MRF Genius Grand Players Edition English Willow Cricket Bat, full-size (SH), is listed at Rs 37349 on TopCricketStore (Online). The substantial difference in price between Kashmir willow bats and high-grade English willow bats from renowned brands like MRF reflects the cost of imported raw materials, extensive manufacturing processes, brand value, and potentially higher marketing and endorsement expenses, even within online retail channels.

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